

Foreword

This atlas of animals is about the living world, from the freezing poles to the tropical equator, from the highest mountain to the deepest sea. But this is no ordinary atlas because it shows where the animals live, as well as what they look like, and the forests, deserts, and oceans that are their homes.

Our planet is a very special part of our solar system: it is the only one with life, and its breathtaking variety should fill us all with wonder. Animals of one kind or another survive almost everywhere on its surface, whether on land or underwater. Scientists have described more than 1.5 million species, and reckon there are many times this number still waiting to be discovered. Some, like the humpback

whale or the osprey, range so far and wide that they span the entire globe. Others, like giant tortoises in the Galápagos Islands, live in less space than a single sprawling city. But all animals only succeed in places that supply what they need to survive and produce their babies, and many have very particular requirements. This means that koalas only live in Australia, where they eat eucalyptus leaves and nothing else, and parrotfish only swim in tropical coastal seas where they can munch on coral.

The animals in this book completely depend upon these wild places, but wilderness—the forests, grasslands, even unspoiled oceans—is disappearing. Since humans started building their civilizations

